Little is known of Coates except that the centenary history of BI describes him as 'the late commander'[45] and that he was the author of an earlier book on shipping (*The Good Old Days of Shipping*, 1900) chronicling the shipping world from at least the mid-1880s. For a European, he demonstrated a modicum of impartiality, chronicling factually correct information about SSNCo in a few pages. Published just before the company was liquidated, Coates, in an effort to be even-handed, defended his description of the aims of SSNCo which he had drawn from its prospectus. 'This part of the book is to record, not to criticize', he pulled a punch before remarking that 'the objects [of the Swadeshi Company] were laudable and the prospectus sufficiently modest.' After outlining its work, he continued, 'the venture in itself, as I have said, sufficiently worthy of commendation, has not been conspicuously successful in fulfilling the objects for which the company was formed'.[46] This guarded statement comes as a salve in contrast to the vicious language of government officials.

The Sense of an Ending

After June 1910 nothing is heard of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company. For many months there was a deafening silence both in the press and in official circles. Following the draconian Indian Press Act, 1910 many of the Swadeshi papers, especially Bharati's *India* and *Vijaya*, had ceased publication by March–April. We therefore know nothing of how the fall of the company was received by them. One of SSNCo's greatest champions and V.O. Chidambaram Pillai's bosom friend, Bharati had no avenue to express his views during this time. For the nationalist press, it must have rent their heart to write about the collapse of a grand dream.

For the police and the government, their many predictions and wishful thinking about the collapse of the company were finally coming true. The durais must have surely gloated in the club over their evening drinks. But that hardly stopped their undercover sleuths from continuing their surveillance. As late as September 1911, the letters of S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, S. Somasundara Bharati, K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar, and Swami